



Empires of Southeast Asia

Situated between India and China, Southeast Asia has always been a region where products, ideas, and faiths from abroad have been debated, exchanged, accommodated, and fought over.

Core area of Pagan Empire	Outermost limit of Pagan Empire
Core area of Dai Viet Empire	Outermost limit of Dai Viet Empire
Core area of Champa Empire	Outermost limit of Champa Empire
Core area of Khmer Empire	Outermost area of Khmer Empire
Core area of Srivijaya Empire	Outermost limit of Srivijaya Empire
Core area of Kadirī Empire	Outermost limit of Kadirī Empire
c. 650–1320	Period of state's duration
(c. 740–1025)	Period of state's apogee

and the Malay Peninsula, dominating the shipping routes through the Straits of Malacca and imposing tolls on the highly profitable spice trade. Other maritime kingdoms, such as the Hindu Kadirī empire, grew in influence as the Srivijaya empire weakened in the 11th century.

The spread of religion

Merchants from India, China, and Sri Lanka brought religion as well as trade to Southeast Asia.

Hinduism first spread among the people of the islands and the mainland much as Mahayana Buddhism (see pp.144–47) later did in the 7th century—on the boats of traders. In Vietnam, Confucianism (see p.127) from China was also integrated into the daily workings of government and society.

The wealth from trade and agriculture financed the building of huge temples and monuments to the gods. Buddhist monuments such as

Borobudur in Java (see left) and the great Hindu temples of Angkor in the Khmer Empire testify to the impact these faiths had on the lives of the people. They also provide evidence of the Southeast Asian belief in the power of the gods to make or break the prosperity granted by the land, rivers, and sea.

Jayavarman II

The great Khmer ruler Jayavarman VII (c. 1125–1215) built vast temples and defeated the Champa, but his excessive spending also impoverished the empire.

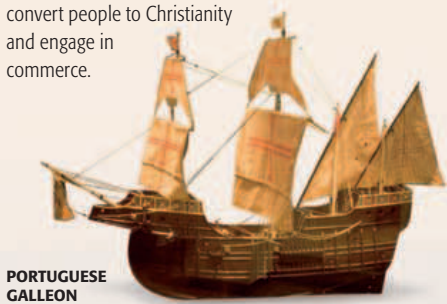
Both Christianity and Islam were exported to Southeast Asia by merchants and traders.

THE SPREAD OF ISLAM

Islam arrived in Southeast Asia with **Arab and Indian traders** from the east coast of India. By the **15th century**, Islam was the most popular religion in Java and Sumatra, transforming statecraft among the sultans and **religious custom** among the peoples of the islands.

EUROPEAN EMPIRE BUILDERS

After the Portuguese seized Malacca on the south of the Malay Peninsula in 1511, **European merchants and missionaries** began to emerge as major players in the commerce and statecraft of Southeast Asia **224–25**. They sought to channel trade through ports that they could control and **convert to Christianity**. Initially limited to the coastal cities, European influence spread across mainland Southeast Asia as **missionaries** traveled inland to convert people to Christianity and engage in commerce.



PORTUGUESE GALLEON

Angkor Wat

Constructed in the 12th century during the reign of the Khmer ruler Suryavarman II and dedicated to the Hindu god of Vishnu, Angkor is the largest religious complex in the world. Measuring nearly 640 acres (260 hectares) in area, its outer wall encircles a temple 210 ft (65 m) tall and comprises over 2,600 ft (800 m) of carved stone.

